The Value Pricing Discovery Call Script

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Stop quoting hourly rates. This is the exact script I use on every discovery call to price based on the value of the problem, not the hours it takes me. This script has closed projects up to $14,840.

BEFORE THE CALL — 5-MINUTE PREP

- Google their company. Know what they do, how many employees, what industry.
- Check their LinkedIn. Know the person's title and how long they've been there.
- Look at their job postings. Open roles reveal pain points (hiring = scaling problems).
- Write down one specific observation: "I noticed you're hiring 3 recruiters right now..."

> **Rule:** The person who asks the questions controls the call. Your job is to listen 80% and talk 20%.

THE 6 DISCOVERY QUESTIONS — WORD FOR WORD

Question 1: "What's the problem you're trying to solve?"

Say this: "Before I talk about what I do, I'd love to understand what's going on in your business right now. What's the main problem you're hoping to solve?"

Why it works: Open-ended. Gets them talking. They'll tell you exactly what to sell them.

Listen for: The emotional words. "Frustrated," "drowning," "behind," "losing." These are buying signals.

Question 2: "What is this problem costing you?"

Say this: "If you had to put a number on it — in time, money, or missed opportunities — what do you think this problem costs your business per month?"

Why it works: Makes the pain tangible. A number they say out loud is a number they believe.

If they can't answer: Help them calculate. "How many hours per week does your team spend on this? What do you pay those people per hour?"

Question 3: "Where is most of the time going?"

Say this: "Walk me through the process right now. Where does most of the time actually go?"

Why it works: Reveals the specific bottleneck you'll automate. This becomes your scope.

Follow up with: "And who's doing that work today? How many people?"

Question 4: "What's stopping you from scaling?"

Say this: "If you wanted to 2x or 3x your volume tomorrow, what breaks first?"

Why it works: Shifts from "fixing a problem" to "unlocking growth." Growth is worth more than savings.

Question 5: "What have you already tried?"

Say this: "Have you tried to solve this before? What happened?"

Why it works: Tells you what failed (so you don't propose it), and shows they've already invested in solving this. They're not tire-kicking — they're committed.

Question 6: "What does success look like?"

Say this: "If we fast-forward 90 days and this is completely solved, what does that look like for you specifically?"

Why it works: They paint the picture of the outcome. That outcome is what you're pricing.

CALCULATE THE PROBLEM'S COST

After the 6 questions, you should have enough to calculate. Do this on the call, out loud.

Variable	How to Get It	Example
Hours wasted per week	Question 3 — "Where does time go?"	10 hrs/week
People involved	Question 3 — "Who's doing this?"	2 recruiters
Hourly cost per person	Ask directly or estimate by role	$40/hr
Weekly cost	Hours x People x Rate	$800/week
Annual cost	Weekly x 50	$40,000/year
Opportunity cost	Question 4 — "What breaks?"	Can't take new clients

Say this on the call: "So just to make sure I'm understanding — right now this is costing you roughly [ANNUAL COST] per year in direct labor, plus you're leaving [OPPORTUNITY] on the table. Does that sound right?"

Wait for them to confirm. They just agreed to the size of their problem.

FRAME YOUR PRICE — THE 5-10% RULE

> **The Rule:** Your project price should be 5-10% of the annual problem cost. If the problem costs $40,000/year, your price is $2,000-$4,000. That's a 10-20x ROI. No rational business says no to that.

Say this: "Based on what you've described, I can build a system that handles [SPECIFIC BOTTLENECK] automatically. The investment for this would be [PRICE]. To put that in perspective, that's [X]% of what this problem costs you annually — meaning you'd see a full return within [TIMEFRAME]."

Real Example

> **Client:** A staffing company in LA. Their recruiters spent 10 hours/week on manual candidate screening at $40/hr across 2 people. That's $800/week = $40,000+/year.
>
> **Solution:** Airtable + n8n automation for resume parsing, scoring, and routing.
>
> **Price:** $3,000
>
> **ROI pitch:** "That's less than 8% of what this costs you annually. You'll make this back in under 4 weeks. And it works 24/7 — no sick days, no onboarding."
>
> **Result:** Hiring time dropped from 6 weeks to under 1 week. Qualified candidate rate jumped from 40% to 78%. They've since expanded the system across all 15 of their offices.

PRESENTING THE PRICE — EXACT SENTENCES

Never say: "My rate is..." or "I charge..." or "The cost is..."

Always say: "The investment for this project is..."

The Three-Option Close

Present three packages. Most people pick the middle one.

Package	What's Included	Price
Core	The automation that solves the main problem. No extras.	$X
Complete (recommended)	Core + dashboard/reporting + 30 days support	$X * 1.5
Premium		

	Complete + training + 90 days support + one expansion	$X * 2.2

Say this: "I've put together three options. Most of my clients go with the Complete package because it includes the reporting dashboard — which means you can actually see the ROI in real-time. But I'll walk you through all three so you can decide what makes sense."

HANDLING "THAT'S TOO EXPENSIVE" — 3 RESPONSES

Response 1: Reframe Against the Problem Cost

Say this: "I totally understand. Let me ask — you mentioned this problem costs about [ANNUAL COST] per year. If we don't solve it, that cost continues. The question isn't whether [PRICE] is a lot of money — it's whether spending [PRICE] to save [ANNUAL COST] makes sense."

Response 2: Compare to the Alternative

Say this: "What would it cost to hire someone full-time to handle this manually? You're looking at $50-70K/year for a coordinator, plus benefits, plus management time. This is a one-time investment that replaces that permanently."

Response 3: Break It Down

Say this: "If we break this down, it's about [DAILY COST] per day over the next year. Your team currently wastes more than that every single morning before lunch. Does it make sense to keep paying [DAILY WASTE] per day in inefficiency to avoid a one-time [PRICE] fix?"

HANDLING "CAN YOU DO IT CHEAPER?" — 2 RESPONSES

Response 1: Reduce Scope, Not Price

Say this: "I can absolutely work with a smaller budget. What I'd recommend is we start with just the [CORE PIECE] — that's the part that solves 80% of your problem. We can do that for [LOWER PRICE]. Then once you see the results, we can add the rest in Phase 2."

Why it works: You never discount. You remove scope. Your rate stays intact.

Response 2: Payment Terms

Say this: "The total investment stays the same, but I can split it into milestones — 40% to start, 30% at midpoint, and 30% on delivery. That way you're seeing results before you've paid the full amount."

Why it works: Reduces perceived risk without reducing your price.

> **Never do this:** Don't say "I can do it for less." The moment you discount, you've told the client your original price was made up. Every future negotiation starts with "can you do it cheaper?" because they know you'll fold.

POST-CALL FOLLOW-UP EMAIL TEMPLATE

Send this within 2 hours of the call. Not the next day. Two hours.

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Subject: [COMPANY NAME] — Automation Project Summary

Hi [NAME],

Great speaking with you today. Here's a quick recap of what we discussed:

THE PROBLEM:
[One sentence describing their pain point in their own words]

THE COST:
Based on our conversation, this is costing your team approximately
[AMOUNT] per year in [time/money/missed opportunities].

THE SOLUTION:
I'll build [specific system description] that [specific outcome]. Here's
what that includes:

- [Deliverable 1]
- [Deliverable 2]
- [Deliverable 3]
- [Deliverable 4]
- 30 days of post-launch support

INVESTMENT:
[PRICE] — representing a [X]x return in year one alone.

TIMELINE:
[X] weeks from kickoff to delivery.

NEXT STEPS:
If you'd like to move forward, I'll send over a simple agreement and we
can start [DAY/DATE]. If you have questions, I'm happy to hop on another
quick call.

Looking forward to it.

[YOUR NAME]
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QUICK REFERENCE — PRICING BY PROJECT TYPE

Project Type	Typical Problem Cost	Your Price Range	ROI Pitch
Email automation	$15-30K/yr in manual outreach	$1,500-$3,000	"Pays for itself in 6 weeks"
Hiring/screening automation	$30-60K/yr in recruiter time	$2,500-$5,000	"Replaces a part-time coordinator"
CRM build-out	$20-50K/yr in lost leads	$3,000-$8,000	"Stops leads from falling through cracks"
Content automation	$25-40K/yr in content production	$2,000-$5,000	"42 posts/month from a 20-min voice memo"
Lead gen system	$40-100K/yr in ad spend	$5,000-$15,000	"Same clients at 30% of your ad spend"

> **Remember:** You're not selling hours. You're selling the delta between their current state and their desired state. A 60-node n8n workflow that took you 2 weeks to build but saves them $100K/year is not a "2-week project." It's a "$100K problem solver." Price accordingly.

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